

By **Ashok Gulati**

# WANTED: A PUSH FOR PULSES

**Having achieved food security and net agriculture produce exporter status, India must now refocus to make a breakthrough in pulses. It also has to tackle nutritional security, malnutrition among young children**

**As we celebrate our 78th Independence day,** we need to look back and see how far we have reached, but also look ahead to our goal of Viksit Bharat@2047. The first and foremost duty of any government is ensuring food security for the people. It's as important as ensuring border security. It was Lal Bahadur Shastri who gave us the slogan, 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan'. Faced with droughts in the mid-1960s, India did not have enough foreign exchange to buy food from the global markets. We needed at least 10 million tonnes (MT) to avert mass starvation deaths. The US came to India's rescue at the time by offering 10 MT of wheat under Public Law 480 (food aid) against rupee payment, which was like a grant, as the rupee had no standing in the global markets. Every 15 minutes, a ship was coming to India with food aid, which was distributed through the PDS (public distribution system). India was considered a 'ship to mouth' economy, and many had given up hope of the country surviving as the population was booming and food supplies were lagging far behind.

The solution to India's precarious food situation then also came from an American, Norman Borlaug. He is the true father of our Green Revolution. His seeds of high yielding varieties (HYV) of wheat (18,000 tonnes of Sonora64 and Lerma Rojo) were imported from Mexico. No wonder he got the Nobel Prize for Peace as he saved millions of lives, perhaps more than what a war takes away. That laid the foundation for our Green Revolution. Around the same time, India also imported HYV seeds of rice (IR-8) from the International Rice Research Institute (IRRI) in the Philippines, for which we have to thank Henry Beachell and Gurdev Khush. The rest is history. Since those days of 'ship to mouth', India is now the largest exporter of rice, accounting for over one-third of global exports. India's rice exports in the past three years equal exports of the grain from Thailand, Vietnam and Pakistan put together. So, in a humble way, India is today contributing to global food security. And this is after giving free rice/wheat (5 kg/per capita/per month) to over 800 million Indians. This must be the biggest programme by any country to give food security to its people.

## THE GIANT STEPS

- From our 'ship to mouth' days in the 1960s, India is now the largest exporter of rice, accounting for over one-third of global exports
- Focusing on pulses and oilseeds is the need of the hour. It will give us much better nutrition with much less damage to groundwater, soil, greenhouse gas emission and biodiversity
- Rationalising agri subsidies and putting the money in R&D, irrigation, water management and rural infrastructure will ensure food and nutritional security in the future

**Focus on pulses and oilseeds:** India's success story on the food front is not just a green (rice) revolution, but also white (milk), blue (fish) and so on. India is a net exporter of agricultural produce. Its exports (roughly $50 billion or Rs 4.2 lakh crore) range from rice, marine products, spices, buffalo meat to several fruits and vegetables. But its imports of food items (roughly $35 billion or Rs 2.9 lakh crore) are highly concentrated in edible oils and pulses. India needs to make